AN ACTOR PREPARES

Despite facing several political setbacks in the past, an assertive Pawan Kalyan, aligned with the NDA, seeks the backing of his Kapu community for a strategic position in the coastal state



STAR POWER JSP chief ▲ Pawan Kalyan at a roadshow in Rajampeta constituency, Andhra Pradesh, Apr. 25

winner. As part of this pragmatism, Pawan is contesting in one assembly seat—Pithapuram—abandoning the ones where he lost in 2019. In the long term, he hopes to use this election as a springboard for an enlarged post-poll political presence, considering Naidu, 74, has declared that this will be his last election whether he wins or loses.

Winning the Kapu heartland of Pithapuram in the Godavari delta may be a daunting task. The YSRCP has fielded Vanga Geetha, the incumbent MP from Kakinada, of which Pithapuram is an assembly segment. In 2029, Pithapuram was won by the YSRCP's P. Dorababu with a 44.7 per cent vote share. Pawan's advantage is that S.V.S.N. Varma, who finished second with 36.7 per cent, is now working for his win though Geetha, also a Kapu, is a tough opponent. To counter his political rivals, who brand him an outsider, he has bought a home in the town and announced that he would live there and work for the local people.

PAWAN BELIEVES THE NDA, BACKED BY THE JSP AND TDP'S 45% VOTE SHARE, NEEDS TO ADD FROM THE REMAINING 10% FOR VICTORY

By tying the scarves of the TDP and BJP around his neck to symbolise the three-party alliance, Pawan led a two-wheeler rally in the constituency on April 23, coinciding with Hanuman Jayanti, when he went to file his nomination papers. "Jagan, an accused in more than 30 cases, is out on bail. However, after the elections, he will be in jail and this is Modi's guarantee," is his assertion in speeches holding up a placard with the image of a glass tumbler—the JSP poll symbol. "The JSP, TDP and the BJP have allied to assure people that law and order issues, corruption and anarchy prevailing in the state will stop."

Beyond his tell-tale aggression and optimism, and the ongoing construction of the JSP headquarters at Mangalagiri in Vijayawada (until now in sheds), analysts are sceptical about his role except in bringing the TDP and BJP together. The JSP is largely a family enterprise. Elder brother K. Nagababu is the party's general secretary. The eldest, Chiranjeevi, who donated Rs 5 crore to the party, sent a recorded video message to campaign for Pawan in Pithapuram after raising expectations earlier about touring the constituency.

"The JSP has conducted Jana Vani to receive representations from people in all districts. This, coupled with the 3,920 meetings and gatherings of Pawan Kalyan, has helped the party as an influential force," says his political secretary P. Hariprasad. But, in last November's Telangana assembly election, where the JSP fielded candidates in constituencies populated with Andhraites, it came a cropper, with seven of the eight contestants losing deposits.

"Though Pawan enjoys considerable clout in the Union government and goodwill of his Kapu community, the influence has dwindled after he joined the NDA and the YSRCP fielded candidates from his community," says B.V. Muralidhar of the Department of Political Science, Sri Venkateswara University, Tirupati. There are other challenges too. "The JSP has not struck grassroots. Pawan does not have the clout to sway voters in favour of the NDA. Winning Pithapuram itself is a challenge," says social commentator A.M. Khan Yazdani.

Having polled 5.5 per cent in 2019 and travelled extensively since then, Pawan has the potential to draw substantial support from his community, which forms about 16 per cent of the population. "The JSP in a circumstantial political reality has been catapulted into significance and not because of its political depth or leadership prowess," says Harathi Vageeshan, who teaches political science at the NALSAR University, Hyderabad. "In a way, the party is clearing some road for the BJP for the future." Only the poll outcome with a vote share of 5 per cent or more will reveal whether the real Pawan Kalyan will stand up. ■